

ROOTED IN SCRIPTURE

Living God's mission

Abigail Duman

Have you ever dreamed of doing something for God, something great in His service, as in being a hero or changing the world? I have good news for you: If you are alive, you are called. You also have two choices—either join the ranks of Jesus, or by default be used as a tool of darkness.

Satan wants to destroy you. God wants to save you. The choice should be easy, shouldn't it? Yet why do so many people hesitate to adopt God's mission for their lives? Maybe they're afraid that it will be too difficult, or they don't want to say no to their naturally sinful human nature. Or maybe they don't realize just how real the battle between good and evil is (we hope that this week's stories will change that!).

But with God, "nothing will be impossible" (Luke 1:37). Do you believe that God can do great things with your life? You'd better believe it! So take up your "sword" (the Bible) and focus on your mission. If you are breathing, if you are reading or hearing these words right now—God is calling *you*.



WALK WITH GOD

Alone on the trail

Onward, Christian soldiers!” a big voice announced over the ring of bicycle bells and eager chatter of voices. Abby adjusted her bicycle helmet. She had been looking forward to this church bike ride for weeks now!

Before long, the group started out. Thick woods lined the paved trail on one side, and a tall chain-link fence on the other. The group crested a little hill that led to a big dip, and Abby reached the bottom first, where she disembarked to explore. That was where she spotted a bone beside the path! *I wonder if a large animal left it here*, she thought with a little shiver.

The rest of the group didn’t pause, so she jumped on her bike and raced after her friends. After going for several miles, someone suggested they turn around. When she spotted her mom also making a U-turn, Abby felt a twinge of disappointment. “Do we really have to go back, Mom?”

“Honey, my legs are going to give out if we go much farther,” Mom said with a laugh. “Besides, your dad and little brother are in the car in the parking lot, waiting for us.”

Abby’s eyes suddenly brightened. “Mom, is it all right if I ride ahead of the group?” With a fresh burst of energy she cycled around the first corner. She felt very independent and strong as she rounded

the next bend; then she noticed how empty the trail was. Cars whizzed past beyond the chain-link fence, and shadows in the dark woods lengthened on her right.

Maybe I should turn around and go back, she wondered. *But no, the parking lot must be around the next bend. I’m almost there!*

Minutes passed, and no parking lot came into view. She cycled faster as she realized that she was alone on the trail, and her heart thumped when two bicyclists appeared and passed her with a nod. Then she noticed a hill ahead—and remembered the bone. How could she have forgotten? *But I’ve gone too far to go back*, she panicked. *I’ve just gone too far.*

She prayed that no wild animal prowled nearby. For a fleeting second she imagined that a mountain lion crouched beside the path. And then in a blur she was past the scary place. It felt like an eternity before she spotted the parking lot. Wonderful sight! She raced to her dad’s car and explained what had happened.

Sometime later she saw a lone figure in the distance, running toward the mouth of the trail. It was Mom—breathless and crying. Abby ran to meet her. “Oh, Abby, I’m so glad that you’re safe,” she said as she hugged her. “Why did you go ahead of me?”

“I’m so sorry, Mama,” she confessed with tear-filled eyes. “I asked you if I could bicycle ahead, didn’t I?”

“You did,” she said. “But you didn’t wait for my reply.”

Have you ever run ahead of God? Learn from Abby’s error; you’ll save yourself a lot of heartache and pain if you never leave to begin with! You need never walk the trail alone! The devil will whisper a lot of lies into your ears during your lifetime, so remember this: You have never gone too far to come home. It doesn’t matter what you’ve done, what you’ve seen, what others have said, or what you might think—Jesus values you. “Yes, I have loved you with an everlasting love,” He says (Jer. 31:3). He wants to be your companion. Will you walk with Him? If so, give Him your hand and your heart—and look forward to the future, because your life’s mission has only begun!

SURRENDER MYSELF

Little is much

I imagine Matthew 14:13-21 went something like this:

“Something is in the air—I can smell it,” Nathan murmured as a breeze filtered through the window.

“Hmm,” Mother remarked. “Maybe it’s a storm brewing over the lake.”

“It’s not that, Mother,” he insisted. “Do you see all the people walking by? Something is happening.”

Upon further investigation, Nathan was right—an intriguing, miracle-working Stranger was in the area, and people of every description were tramping in one direction. “*Pleease*, can I go to see Him?” Nathan begged. “I want to hear Him speak.”

Nathan’s mother paused. “Hold on long enough for me to pack you a lunch.” Before long she had a basket in her hand with a few loaves and two small fish. “Here you go, Nathan—do be careful. Don’t be gone too long!”

Finding Jesus wasn’t difficult. Thousands of people crowded around Him, surrounded by a field of wildflowers and tall grasses overlooking the beautiful lake. Nathan got as close to the Teacher as he dared and then sat down to listen. He listened so well that when a disciple of Jesus approached him, he barely noticed. “Pardon me, young man,” a kind voice said. “Would you be willing to share your lunch with the Master?”

Nathan swallowed as he nodded and suddenly realized how empty his stomach felt. “But it’s not much—just five loaves and two small fish.”

The disciple smiled. “It’s enough.”

Nathan blinked. When he thought of the priests with their costly robes, pompous words, and countless rules, he never felt good enough for God. But the disciple’s words spelled out a new sort of hope—one that said God wouldn’t refuse the smallest gift when it came from the heart.

His eyes followed his lunch as it passed into Jesus’ hands. When the kind Teacher smiled and locked eyes with his young face, Nathan sensed that Jesus knew



everything about him and loved him still. *There’s no other way to describe it!* Nathan marveled.

Jesus prayed a blessing over the lunch and then began to break the loaves into pieces. Nathan’s eyes grew wide with astonishment—by now his mother’s five loaves should have been used up. Yet Jesus’ hands continued to draw out more loaves and fish. Thousands of people sat on the hillside and ate their fill!

Nathan gripped a barley loaf in his hands and inspected it. *I’m holding a miracle*, he thought to himself. *And to think that Jesus used what little I had to make it happen!*

Maybe sometimes you’ve been tempted to think that your life doesn’t mean much in the grand scheme of things. But if Jesus fed more than 5,000 with a little boy’s lunch, what do you think He can do with your *life* if you give it to Him?

Nathan didn’t have to “grow up” to do some big thing for God. The gift of his lunch—and the gift of his heart—may have seemed small, but were priceless in Jesus’ eyes. So what about you? Will you give Him your moments? Nothing is too large—or too small—to give to Jesus.

When you surrender yourself to Him, you are allowing His mighty power to work through you. This is how we can have “treasure in earthen vessels” (2 Cor. 4:7). You are a vessel; He is the treasure. Together you make a wonderful team!



LIVE IT

The field's on fire

How you live says more about God's love than the words you speak. Tim knew all about fires. He knew how not to start them, he knew how to put them out, and what to do if he were on fire (stop, drop, and roll). His mom taught him wildfire statistics and talked about the fires that ravaged the countryside. She even bought fire safety stickers for him to share with his friends. And most of all, she stressed that he should *never* play with matches. Out of all the boys and girls at Tim's school, he had the most knowledge about fire safety.

But deep down, Tim wanted to play with fire. On the outside he looked obedient and cooperative, but on the inside he was waiting for an opportunity—any moment when his mom might be distracted—to grab a wad of matches and slip them into his pocket. And sure enough, that day came.

Tim patted the bulge in his pocket on his way to school and thought about what he would do with the forbidden treasure. "I'll find a safe spot to strike one," he planned.

On his walk home from school, Tim passed a large field with a small barn beside the road. No one lived across the street, and when Tim sank down in the grass, he was invisible to any passersby. Eagerly he pushed the grasses aside and lit a match. The flame flickered in the breeze. Tim's eyes were aglow with fascination as the flame traveled down to the end of the matchstick. "Ow!" he exclaimed. Without thinking, he dropped the burning match into a grassy hole, where, try as he might, he could not snuff out the flame. The fire licked up the dry grasses, then escaped into the field.

Tim soon realized that there was nothing that he could do to stop the fire. With an empty pit in his stomach he walked the rest of the way home and silently entered the house.

"Hi, honey," Mom said from the kitchen. Suddenly she gasped. "I see smoke coming from the field down the road. I need to call the fire department!"

Tim ran back to the field with his mom, where perspiring men fought to stop an out-of-control blaze. The beautiful field became charred, and the barn burned to the ground. When the fire was out, Tim wasn't relieved: He realized his disobedience had cost the town a lot of money and risked people's lives. For Tim, fire safety knowledge was good, but not enough. He needed to act on what he knew.

What about you? Maybe you have a lot of knowledge about the Bible, but you're not obeying what it teaches. If, like Tim, you know what's right, but you're not living it, ask God for help! He is calling you to do more than just talk about His goodness or look obedient to His commands on the outside—He's calling you to *be* His witness. Being a witness doesn't mean that you are perfect; it means that you ask God to help you give your best. You have one life: Live it for Jesus!

LISTEN TO THE HOLY SPIRIT

Danger on the woodpile



Luke scanned the yard for anything of interest. His dad and grandmother were deep in conversation beside the porch steps, and he was incredibly bored. When he spotted a large pile of firewood at the edge of the yard, his eyes brightened, and he took off in its direction.

“Don’t go near the woodpile.” The voice in Luke’s head made him pause. *Could God be speaking to me?* He wasn’t sure. Why, he was just a kid! But he did know that he wanted to climb that woodpile. I don’t see any danger, he thought. He shrugged his shoulders and continued downhill until he reached a large log and began to climb.

Suddenly a loud rattling sound filled the surrounding air with a sense of alarm. Only a few feet ahead of him a long snake was curled up, preparing to strike. In an instant Luke was petrified. He had never seen a rattlesnake before in his life! Yet he instinctively knew that it was dangerous. What could he do? He began to yell as he backed away—and then, to his horror, he realized that his little brother Daniel had toddled to the woodpile after him and didn’t seem to recognize the danger!

Dad came running. “A rattler!” he exclaimed. Grandmother grabbed Daniel’s hand and pulled him away from the snake. Luke’s heart thumped as he ran up the hill and into the house, where Mom hugged them both. “Praise God that you were saved from being bitten,” she exclaimed over and over. Her hands trembled, and her eyes filled with tears.

“Mama, I heard a voice in my mind that told me not to go to the woodpile,” Luke later confessed.

“That was the voice of the Holy Spirit,” Mom replied. “Listen to that voice, and as you grow older, it will save you from many troubles.”

“A lot of thoughts come into my brain. How do I know which ones are from the Holy Spirit?” Luke wondered.

“That’s a good question,” Mom replied, pausing to think. “It’s important to spend time in the Bible. As you read God’s words, you will learn to recognize His voice. The Holy Spirit will always tell you to do what’s right, and you can test the thoughts against what you’ve learned in the Bible.”

Luke shivered when he thought of how close he had come to the rattlesnake, and Mom placed her hand on his shoulder. “God warns us in Matthew 26:41 that we should ‘watch and pray,’ because we have an enemy who wants to destroy us.”

“The devil.”

“Yes, that’s right,” she nodded.

“But he’s not going to win,” Luke said. “Jesus wins. And I’m going to do my best to listen to His voice.”

“That’s a big part of watching and praying,” Mom smiled. “Our only true safety is found in Jesus. When you listen to the Holy Spirit, not only are you blessed and closer to heaven because of it, but you also become a powerful witnessing tool in God’s hands. That’s how you can accomplish His mission for your life.”

Luke thought for a moment. “I don’t know exactly what God wants me to do, but I have a pretty good idea for now—listen for His directions.”

Mom smiled, because Luke suddenly looked exceedingly wise for his years. “That’s exactly right,” she said. “Let God’s Word and Spirit guide you.”

PRAY AND MOVE

When Mother prayed

God is looking for humble people who are willing to go on missions for heaven—even if that means just a simple phone call, a few words, or a sincere prayer. Are you willing to stop and listen to His voice?

The weather forecast warned of an approaching storm with wind gusts of more than 60 miles (96 kilometers) per hour. As the sky darkened and the wind began to whistle, Bryce carefully guided his car home. Springtime storms were not uncommon in his area of the eastern United States, but they were rarely severe.

Back at the house, Bryce's parents sensed that this storm was an angry one. Thunder and lightning increased as strong winds tossed trees and tore off branches. "This is becoming much worse than we expected," Mom remarked. "I would feel better if I knew that Bryce wasn't driving through it."

"God's angels are with him," Dad touched her gently on the shoulder. "He's in good hands."

When the sound of the wind changed from a howl to the rumble of a driving train overhead, the couple sought shelter in the back bathroom—away from windows and outer walls—for safety. As they huddled together, they prayed for their son's safety. Then suddenly Mom raised her head. Something prompted her to do something specific. "Call Bryce. Call him now!"

"OK," Dad said as he reached for his cell phone.

Meanwhile, Bryce struggled to view the road as wind and rain buffeted the car. Windshield wipers barely kept the water off the windshield, and small, tumbling branches scratched the sides of his car. With some relief he reached the familiar road that led to his driveway. Suddenly he heard a crack, and a large tree fell with a crash—directly in front of his car. Leaves flew in every direction. "Whoa!" Bryce exclaimed. *What to do next?* He shifted his car into reverse and began to back away from the blockage. And that was when his phone rang.

It's Dad. Bryce pressed his foot on the brake and then clamped the phone to his ear. "Hello?"

Crack—crash. His car reeled with the impact of a massive tree trunk. Metal bent and glass shattered as another tree crashed through the back of his car and flattened the rear passenger section.

"Son, are you OK?" Dad asked.

Bryce blinked. "Yeah, I think so. But my car isn't—there's a tree in my back seat!"

He leaped outside and surveyed the downed tree in front of the car, and the tree on the back of it. "A few seconds more, and I would have been sitting where that second tree fell."

"Praise God for His protection," Dad breathed. "I'll come and get you."

Once Bryce safely arrived home, they reviewed every detail of the experience together with awe. In response to prayer, God convicted a mother to call her son when seconds made all the difference.

In a way, life is a storm—a clash between light and darkness, a testing time that determines whom we put our trust in. Are you turning to the One who can guide you through the storm? Listen for God's voice—a quiet, steady voice in your mind that reminds you to do right—and respond. Be ready to act when He speaks! Every second counts when it comes to working in His service! And the good news? The joy of working for the King of kings lasts *forever*.





SHARE THE MESSAGE

Angels in the graveyard

Editor's Note for Parents/Guardians: This true story includes references to spiritual conflict and supernatural themes that some children may find intense. While the events described are more dramatic than what most children experience, the Bible reminds us that the enemy often works in quiet, subtle ways to influence hearts and choices. Parents are encouraged to read the story first and talk it through with their children afterward.

Sshhh,” Marguerite* whispered as wind tossed the branches of a palm tree far above her. “We’re almost there.”

Kisangani, a city in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, is home to more than 1.6 million people—and many of them are children. In this big city beside the Congo River, spiritual battles between light and darkness are very real. Even adults are afraid of witchcraft and the dangers it can bring people involved in it. This is why one group of young people kept a dark secret—that they were being trained to be witches.

Marguerite slipped to the outskirts of town and into a graveyard where some of her friends were already waiting. The evil angels were late this evening. Night after night they personally trained Marguerite and her friends in sorcery. Marguerite liked the idea of having special “powers” and being called a witch, even though she was still a child.

“Our teachers are late tonight. I wonder what has held them up,” Marguerite spoke aloud.

“Maybe they are keeping our parents fast asleep so that they do not miss us,” one of her friends said.

Suddenly a flash of light enveloped the group. Instantly they knew that this presence was different. Marguerite fell to the ground and squinted as she held up a hand to shield her face. Out of the light she could see the form of a heavenly being.

“What are you doing here?” a voice spoke firmly. “You do not have time for this.”

The night rituals and the hours she spent under the demons’ instruction paled in comparison to the words of this new visitor.

When the children did not reply, the angel spoke again: “Jesus is coming soon.”

This world is full of material that will draw you away from God. Is there anything in your life that isn’t preparing you for God’s kingdom—and maybe better preparing you to live in darkness? If so, put it away. God is speaking to you today: You don’t have time for this. Jesus is coming soon!

That night in the graveyard changed everything for Marguerite and her friends. They told their parents everything and refused to meet the demons again. They opened their hearts to the Holy Spirit and felt a burning desire to share the angel’s message with the people in Kisangani. Many churches opened their doors to hear the story from the lips of the children who wanted to tell the world that Jesus was coming soon and that no one had time to be baited by the devil’s tricks. Marguerite’s testimony was powerful, and many people were touched by her experience in a graveyard where heavenly angels intercepted demons. Less than a year later Marguerite attended an evangelistic series in her city and was baptized into the Seventh-day Adventist Church along with her family.

Did you know that you have a testimony to share? Do you believe that Jesus is coming soon? Look for opportunities to share what He has done for you! Maybe He’s given you victory over sin or obviously protected you from danger. Just like Marguerite, be ready to listen to His voice and share what He has done for you! He will give you courage to fulfill His mission!

* Names have been changed for privacy.

LOVE LIKE JESUS

The canceled funeral

What does witnessing look like? It is being like Jesus. Being kind no matter how unkindly you are treated. Loving the people who are difficult to love. It doesn't mean that you are always perfect, but that you are allowing Jesus to perfectly work through you!

Ever since Tembo's heart was captured by the beauty of God's Word, he knew that he wanted to walk with God, to listen to His voice, and to stay connected with heaven through prayer. Everyone loved Tembo for being kind, thoughtful, and spirit-filled—everyone, that is, except for Juma.* Juma had disliked Tembo ever since they first met. He taunted him and whispered untrue stories behind his back. Sometimes this affected Tembo's reputation, but Tembo was always kind.

"Did you hear that Juma is very sick?" someone told Tembo one sunny Tanzanian day. "No one—not even his family—wants to be around him, for there is a very bad smell, and no one can stand being in the house except for his wife."

Tembo felt a quiet voice speak to his mind: *Go and help Juma.* Without hesitation Tembo did. To Tembo's surprise, Juma's family was waiting outside when he reached the house. "What are you doing here?" one man scoffed.

"I'm here to help Juma," Tembo said.



“He’s not going to live much longer,” another relative said. “And if you step through his door to help and he dies, we will hold you responsible for paying the funeral costs.”

Tembo thought for a moment. Funerals in Tanzania could cost several thousand dollars, and he didn’t have that kind of money. But he couldn’t let his enemy die without knowing Jesus’ love.

As soon as Tembo entered the house, the stench inside overpowered him. His stomach churned, and his lungs begged for fresh air. But when Tembo saw the terrible sore on Juma’s skin, he knew that God had sent him just in time. Praying for stamina and a strong stomach, Tembo turned to Juma’s wife. “I need clean clothes and water to wash his wound. Once I am finished, I will pay for transportation and get him to the hospital right away.”

Juma’s eyes widened, but his lips didn’t move. Tembo gently cleaned the wound and did what he had promised; he paid for the hospital treatments and visited Juma often.

Days passed, and a change happened in Juma’s heart. He tried to understand why Tembo would do such a thing for someone who had

treated him so terribly. “When my relatives were waiting for me to die, you took the risk to try to save me,” he marveled.

When Juma recovered enough to return home, Tembo accompanied him. And when they arrived, relatives were swarming around Juma’s house, expecting his funeral. They also expected Tembo to pay according to their agreement. As they walked into the circle of relatives, Juma pointed to his new friend, Tembo: “Do you see this man? He showed me a love that even my relatives did not have. *He* has become my family.” The funeral didn’t happen, and the relatives went home. Because of Tembo’s selfless act of love, Juma came to know God too.

Do you want to be a missionary, maybe allow God to use you to change the world? If so, love Him first and best—and loving others will happen naturally. Start in your corner of the world, wherever that is, and love the people that He places in your path, whoever they are. Walk with purpose and “hold fast” to your faith (Rev. 3:11). Not a gift, a prayer, or a moment is wasted in the service for the King of kings! 

* Names have been changed for privacy.



Abigail Duman is a freelance writer who lives in West Virginia, United States, with her husband and three boys, where they enjoy outdoor adventures together.



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